

REACHING FOR THE STARS

A hockey player from a remote village in Jharkhand who dreams of playing for India in the Olympics, a civil servant who ushered in a 'space revolution' by launching astronomy labs in some 100 state-run schools in Uttar Pradesh, the 'Mushroom Lady' from desert state Rajasthan who launched a women's collective, a young tea farmer from Dibrugarh, Assam, who dreams of taking his produce global... these are some of the 'Bhagya Vidhatas' who signify a rising, aspirational India. And they were all at the India Today Conclave.

Manoj Konbegi, vice-president of Hockey Jharkhand, spoke about how losing the Nehru Cup school nationals final to Haryana led to the development of an astroturf hockey stadium in Simdega, now christened the 'cradle of hockey' in Jharkhand. Hailing from a nearby village where hockey is religion—school children can forget their satchels but not their hockey sticks here—is a young Sanjna Dungdung, centre-forward and captain of her school team who battles poverty and sweats it out on the hockey field as she chases her dream of playing in the Olympics.

As the chief development officer (CDO) of Bulandshahr (2020-22), Abhishek Pandey inspired children and adults alike to reach for the stars. The young IAS officer initiated the 'astronomy labs' idea in 2021 when the second Covid wave was raging and there were fears of the learning gap widening in schools. Now, the 'Khagol Kranti' has spread, with some 100 government schools boasting their own astronomy labs.

Meanwhile, providing more proof that farmers are the mainstay of the country are Annu Kanawat, the 'Mushroom Lady' who launched a shroom cultivation collective that has transformed the lives of thousands of women in Rajasthan, and tea garden entrepreneur Gaurab Kumar Das whose story runs parallel to that of the Bogibeel bridge that has helped bring Arunachal Pradesh and Assam closer, in commerce as well as in culture. ■

IN 2010, THE WOMEN'S HOCKEY TEAM FROM SIMDEGA PLAYED THE NEHRU HOCKEY FINAL FOR THE FIRST TIME AND LOST...ONLY BECAUSE THEY HAD NO ASTROTURF TO PRACTISE ON IN THE DISTRICT. WE WORKED WITH CONVICTION AND GOT AN ASTROTURF IN SIMDEGA IN 2015. TODAY, MANY GIRLS FROM JHARKHAND ARE PLAYING FOR INDIA. IN THE SENIOR INDIA TEAM, WE HAVE FOUR PLAYERS, INCLUDING TWO FROM KARANGAGURI

1. MANOJ KONBEGI
Vice-president, Hockey Jharkhand

I liked the movie *Chak De! India*. I want to be part of the Olympics like those players, make my country proud. But we have to work very hard. It'll not be easy. My mother works as a domestic help in Mumbai for Rs 10,000 a month, my father is a farmer. I stay at a day-boarding centre

2. SANJNA DUNGDUNG
School hockey captain